

Rock

Rocks are made of one or more minerals. They don't look like they could travel very far on their own, but they do! Rocks move through the Earth, making their way from the surface to deep down under our feet, and returning back up again. Along the way, over millions of years, they go through huge changes.

On the beach

Over time, rock pieces settle as sand, mud, or pebbles on the coast. Usually, they get carried into the sea by rivers and settle on the seabed. Sometimes, they remain on land and compress and solidify into solid rock.

See also

Find out more about how rocks form in continents (22–23) and volcanoes (30–31).

Under the sea

Gradually, tiny pieces of rock on the seabed pile on top of each other and stick together. When the rocks compact in this way, they form sedimentary rocks.

Some pieces of sedimentary rock are dragged down farther inside the Earth.

Sedimentary Colorful bands of layered sedimentary rock are found in Badlands National Park in South Dakota.



Igneous Obsidian is an igneous rock that formed thousands of years ago when lava cooled quickly at the Earth's surface. Broken pieces of obsidian have very sharp edges.



Metamorphic Schist is a metamorphic rock that was once shale or mudstone. It is made of layers of minerals that have been folded and crumpled, which you can see in the bands of colors.

